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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

US, Russia open door for closer ties

Saudi Arabia site of first key talks since Ukraine war started

By Matthew Lee, Justin Spike and Barry Hatton
Associated Press

RIYADH, Saudi Arabia — Senior American and Russian officials, including the countries' top diplomats, will hold talks on improving their ties and negotiating an end to the war in Ukraine, offi-

cials said Monday, in what would be the most significant meeting between the sides since Moscow's full-scale invasion of its neighbor nearly three years ago.

The talks scheduled for Tuesday in Saudi Arabia mark another pivotal step by the Trump administration to reverse U.S. policy on isolating Russia, and are meant

to pave the way for a meeting between President Donald Trump and Russian President Vladimir Putin.

The recent U.S. diplomatic blitz on the war has sent Kyiv and key allies scrambling to ensure a seat at the table amid concerns that Washington and Moscow could press ahead with a deal that won't

be favorable to them. France called an emergency meeting of European Union countries and the U.K. on Monday to decide how to respond.

Russian Foreign Minister Sergey Lavrov and Putin's foreign affairs adviser Yuri Ushakov arrived in the Saudi capital on Monday, according to Russian state TV. Ushakov said the talks would be "purely bilateral" and would not include Ukrainian officials.

The U.S. delegation, he said, is made up of "serious people" but said Russia "came with a serious approach too." It is important, Ushakov said, "to start the real normalization of relations" between Russia and the United States.

U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio, national security adviser Mike Waltz and Special Envoy

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ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

CHILL RIDE

A person rides a Divvy bike in downtown Chicago on Monday. According to the National Weather Service, the Chicago area will see bitterly cold weather this week, with single-digit temperatures and subzero wind chills. Wind can make cold air temperatures feel much more frigid to humans and animals as it draws heat away from the body when it comes into contact with exposed skin. The week's frigid conditions mean heightened risks for hypothermia and frostbite in under 30 minutes. Wind chills of minus 10 to minus 25 degrees are expected Monday through Wednesday.

Housing authority owed millions

Leases unenforced, residents failing to pay rent, report finds

By Lizzie Kane
Chicago Tribune

More than 1,000 Chicago Housing Authority residents who are behind on rent have not paid for an average of nearly two years.

CHA's Office of the Inspector General report from the last quarter of 2024 found that as of March 1, 2024, CHA was owed more than \$10.4 million dollars in rent by these 1,394 residents and was failing to enforce its lease agreements with them.

CHA is the third largest public housing authority in the country, serving more than 65,000 households, and it also is the largest single owner of rental housing in the city with more than 21,000 public housing units. The agency has a 2025 budget of \$1.3 billion.

The OIG advisory comes as the agency is managing senior staff turnover, including in its general counsel position, and is searching for a permanent replacement for former CEO Tracey Scott.

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Couple lose home on their wedding day

Cicero explosion leaves one dead, others displaced

By Carolyn Stein
Chicago Tribune

Tom Davis and Eleni Vrettos were supposed to be celebrating the happiest day of their lives on Saturday, but instead after their vows, the bride and groom found themselves racing to their Cicero home after learning it had exploded.

Dressed in her gown and heels, Vrettos trudged her way through the snow to find smoke streaming out of the place she called home for most of her life. Her beloved cats, who she called her children and named signature drinks after at the wedding, gone.

"I haven't slept or eaten," Vrettos said Monday. "I'm just devastated. My stomach's in knots."

The investigation into why the home in the 2200 block of Central Avenue exploded about 5 p.m. Saturday remains ongoing, officials said. The explosion left one person dead and displaced multiple families, according to town officials.

A total of 11 units and fami-

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EILEEN T. MESLAR/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Protesting on Presidents Day

People rally outside Trump Tower in a Refuse Facism protest after marching from Federal Plaza and Millennium Park in Chicago on Monday. Refuse Fascism called on people across the country to take to the streets to protest Trump administration decisions on a variety of issues such as immigration, domestic and foreign policies.

Quinn calls for ethics reform

Former Illinois Gov. Pat Quinn challenges Gov. JB Pritzker to push for stronger ethics laws, especially after the conviction of ex-state House Speaker Michael Madigan. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

Giving a boost to the Loop

The latest return-to-office mandates may help give a significant boost to restaurants and catering businesses in Chicago, especially in the Loop. **Business**

Wildlife trafficking fight proves a tall order

Tale of 5 smuggled spider monkeys reveals difficulties

By Adriana Pérez
Chicago Tribune

Behind the scenes at the Brookfield Zoo, five spider monkeys are preparing to make their public debut this summer. Their journey began more than a year ago when they were confiscated from smugglers at the Mexican border after being snatched from the wild, their mothers killed in the process.

Found malnourished and in diapers, the baby monkeys faced a long road to recovery. Three of them, captured together in Tijuana, Mexico, were sent to the San Diego Zoo Wildlife Alliance, and the other two went to the Houston Zoo. They were bottle-fed and socialized by animal care teams for a year and a half.

Now, their new caretakers at the Brookfield Zoo are sharing their story to highlight the illegal exotic pet trade and the threat it poses to endangered animals — especially as many buyers don't realize the creatures sold on the black market

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